other ritualistic supplies—plus a priest's services. What's sold as sandalwood is now a cheap imitation; scarcity has made the real thing unaffordable to most people. However, this custom is quite old. In the 1660s, Frenchman Tavernier observed, 'According to the wealth of the deceased, there is mingled with the ordinary wood which is collected for burning, more or less sandal-wood or other scented wood.'[45] The cheapest funeral package now costs about Rs 5000 in total. A middle-class family might spend 30,000 on a package with more wood, more lavish rituals and finer oblations for the fire.

The actual cremation—setting up and clearing each pyre, managing its burning, gathering of remains in an urn, etc.—is all done by the Doms, a group earlier classified as 'untouchable' that claims descent from a mythological figure called Kallu Dom. The Doms recognize a presumed patrilineal heir of Kallu Dom as their king, the Dom Raja. He 'rules' the burning ghats and lives with his family on the riverfront, a short walk south of Manikarnika Ghat. When I visit, I see no evidence of his rumoured fabulous wealth in their rustic, two-storey, brightly painted home. In their courtyard overlooking the river are two sculpted tigers, a symbolic assertion of power by a relatively recent ancestor. Unburnt wood from the cremation grounds traditionally fuels the stove in their kitchen.